Madhavendra Puri

Мадхавендра Пури · @madhavendra-puri

The First Sprout of the Tree of Devotion

Madhavendra Puri came into the world as early as the fourteenth century, long before Sri Chaitanya, and yet in His lila he stands at the very source. Before coming into the world, the Lord sends ahead those whom He will honour as parents, teachers and elders, so that each of them may serve Him in his own way:

“Before descending to the Earth, Krishna sends here many of His devotees, who accept the roles of His venerable forebears, teachers and elders.” (CC, Adi 3.92)

“Madhavendra Puri, Ishvara Puri, Srimati Shachimata and Jagannatha Mishra appeared together with Advaita Acharya.” (CC, Adi 3.94)

Elsewhere the “Charitamrita” (Adi 13.52–55) names this circle of elders in greater detail: “Madhava Puri,” Shachi, Jagannatha Mishra, Keshava Bharati, Ishvara Puri, Advaita, Srivasa, Acharyaratna, Pundarika Vidyanidhi and Haridasa. Thus Gaurasundara, in whom Radha and Madhava are united, revealed on earth His elders in the chain of teachers even before His own appearance in Sridham Mayapur-Navadvipa. Lochana Dasa adds in the “Chaitanya-mangala” that together with the Lord, with Nityananda — Balarama — and Advaita — Shiva — and His other eternal companions, both Ishvara Puri and Madhavendra Puri descended.

Vrindavana Dasa in the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Adi 9.155–160) speaks of him in a way that leaves little to add: his body is woven of divine love, and all who are near him are full of it; he knows no food but the taste of Krishna; Krishna Himself plays within his body; and if one more proof of his love is needed, it is enough to say that his disciple was Advaita Acharya. Gaurachandra would say again and again, “Madhavendra is the first architect (adi-sutradhara) of the rasa of devotion,” and He called him the original fountainhead of jubilant love for Krishna.

Krishnadasa Kaviraja, describing Sri Chaitanya's tree of devotion, begins with him:

“All glory to Sri Madhavendra Puri, the treasury of unalloyed loving service to Krishna! In him this wish-fulfilling tree of bhakti first sprouted.” (CC, Adi 9.10)

“Then this seed of the wish-fulfilling tree of bhakti took the form of a new shoot — Sri Ishvara Puri. And soon the gardener Himself, Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu, became the main trunk of this tree of bhakti.” (CC, Adi 9.11)

The gardener and the trunk of this tree is Mahaprabhu Himself; it was planted in Navadvipa and grew up in Puri and Vrindavana. Madhavendra is its first sprout, the one in which the seed of devotion first bore fruit; Ishvara Puri is that same sprout grown strong and tall; higher up the trunk divides into two — Advaita and Nityananda (CC, Adi 9.21) — while below it is held by nine roots, the sannyasis of whom we shall speak further on (CC, Adi 9.13–15).

The “Bhakti-ratnakara” (5.2272–2274) calls Madhavendra loving devotion embodied: the mere remembrance of his name brings every perfection, and Ishvara Puri, Ranga Puri and his other disciples are intoxicated with the taste of bhakti; and he had many disciples firm in such devotion throughout Bengal and Orissa. The “Charitamrita” extols him as the spiritual teacher of the whole world, the giver of divine love (CC, Antya 8.31). The Gaudiya tradition sees in him an intimate companion of Sri Vrishabhanu-nandini — Radha, the original abode of love — and of Sri Radha-Giridhari; even eternally perfect devotees worship his feet. He is the parama-guru of Gaura, Nityananda and Advaita, playing the

part of a revered preceptor, and both Vallabhacharya and his son Vitthalanatha always worshipped him.

He bore several names. Most often he is called Madhavendra Puri or Madhava Puri; his disciples and intimates said “Puri Gosani,” “Puri Gosvami,” “Shripada,” “Puripada”; in the writings of Vallabha's followers he is Madhavendra Yati or Madhava Yatindra, and the “Vallabha-digvijaya” calls him simply “the brahmana Madhava.”

Heir to the Line of Madhva

In the age of Kali the world is purified by four Vaishnava lines of succession — the sampradayas of Brahma, Sri, Rudra and the Sanakas. Bhaktivinoda Thakura explains in the “Amrita-pravaha-bhashya” that the Vaishnavas who teach pure devotion on the basis of the Vedanta are divided into these four branches. Madhavendra belonged to the Brahma, or Madhva, sampradaya: he accepted the line of Sri Madhvacharya and Vaishnava sannyasa and became a guru within it.

The succession of Madhva is recorded in the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika,” in the “Prameya-ratnavali” and by Gopala Guru Gosvami; almost the same verses, with small variant readings, are given in the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (5.2149–2162). According to the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” (22), the chain runs thus: the Lord of the spiritual world — Brahma — Narada — Vyasa — Shuka; from Vyasa Madhvacharya received the mantra of Krishna, and after him came Padmanabha, Narahari, Madhava-dvija, Akshobhya, Jayatirtha, Jnanasindhu, Mahanidhi, Vidyanidhi, Rajendra and Jayadharma; from Jayadharma's circle also came Vishnu Puri, the author of the “Bhakti-ratnavali.” Then the line passes through Purushottama[1] to Vyasatirtha, the author of the “Vishnu-samhita,” from him to Lakshmipati Tirtha, and from Lakshmipati to Madhavendra Puri.

Vyasatirtha was an ascetic of the Vyasaraya Matha and stood fourteenth in descent from Madhva in the Madhva-Gaudiya chain. According to one opinion, his disciple was Lakshmipati Tirtha, and Madhavendra was the follower of the latter; Madhavendra, then, was a disciple of Vyasatirtha's disciple. Vyasatirtha left the “Nyayamrita,” the “Tatparya-chandrika,” the “Tarka-tandava,” the “Bheda-ujjivana,” the three “Khandana-traya-mandara-manjaris” and the “Tattva-viveka-mandara-manjari”; even the foremost Mayavadis acknowledged the “Nyayamrita.” An old Bengali verse says the same: Vyasatirtha was Madhva's servant, Lakshmipati was Vyasa's servant, from him came Madhavendra Puri, and among the disciples of the great Madhavendra were Ishvara, Nityananda and Advaita; and a Sanskrit stanza honours his disciples — Ishvara, Advaita and Nityananda, the gurus of the world — and Sri Chaitanya, the disciple of Ishvara.

The “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” adds that it was Madhavendra who set this dharma in motion — and his path lives on to this day. There he is also called an incarnation of the wish-fulfilling tree that grows in Vraja, bearing four fruits: servitude (dasya), friendship (sakhya), parental love (vatsalya) and conjugal love (ujjvala). His disciple Ishvara Puri accepted the fruit of shringara, Advaita two fruits, dasya and sakhya, and Sri Ranga Puri took shelter of vatsalya (GGD 23–24).[2]

Of his homeland only Vallabha's followers give any account. Yadunatha's “Vallabha-digvijaya” (section 1, 1658 of the Vikrama era) calls him “Madhavendra Yati, an Andhra, a follower of the Madhva sampradaya, an incarnation of the rishi Shandilya”; the “Nij-varta” calls him a Telugu brahmana, an acharya of the Madhva sampradaya and the guru of Krishna Chaitanya; the “252 Vartas” — a sannyasi of the Madhva sampradaya who lived at Arail.

What was new in this ancient line was what Madhavendra himself brought into it. Bhaktivinoda Thakura writes that the disciple of his disciple was Sri Chaitanya, and that before him there is no evidence of loving devotion (prema-bhakti) in the line of Madhva; from Madhvacharya down to Lakshmipati, Madhavendra's guru, it knew no devotion filled with the taste of conjugal love — what the

spirit of Madhva's followers then was can be seen from Mahaprabhu's conversation with the Tattvavadis in the south. Madhavendra, by composing the verse “ayi dīna-dayārdra nātha,” sowed the seed of such devotion, and in that verse lies the germ of Mahaprabhu's entire teaching. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati calls him the first sprout of the wish-fulfilling tree of divine love to rise from the line of Madhva: before him there was not a trace of the conjugal mood in it.

Before Madhavendra, down to Lakshmipati Tirtha, this line worshipped Krishna alone; from Madhavendra there descended into it love for Krishna in separation (vipralambha), rooted in wholehearted service to Sri Radha. Only those in whom a taste for it has awakened, and who are bound to him by dear ties, are eligible for it. The great souls say: Madhavendra is the root of the tree of shringara-rasa, Ishvara Puri its shoot, Mahaprabhu the main trunk, and His followers the branches and twigs. And in our own time Bhakti Vilasa Tirtha, in a speech at Udupi, recalled that the root of the Gaudiya sampradaya is the succession of Madhva, and that Madhavendra, Mahaprabhu's parama-guru and the first artist of loving devotion, belonged to it, while Mahaprabhu is the chief preacher of that devotion in the mood of separation. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta visited Udupi more than once, collected Madhva literature and invited a swami from there to teach Madhva philosophy at the head matha in Mayapur.

Intoxicated with Love

Even before the Lord's appearance Madhavendra lived in a state that the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Antya 4.402–412) describes with wonder. Trembling, tears, hair standing on end, roaring and thunderous cries, loud laughter, stupor and perspiration never left him. Absorbed in Govinda, he was unaware of the outer world: walking along a road he would break into dance of his own accord, calling out to Hari; at times he lay unconscious for two or three praharas; in separation he wept in torrents like the Ganga, and in a moment of bliss he would forget even his clothing. Day and night, intoxicated with love for Krishna, he would laugh, weep and cry “Hai, hai!” like a madman (CB, Adi 9). At the mere sight of a cloud — it reminded him of Krishna — he would fall senseless.

He lived by the vow of ayachaka-vritti: he never asked for food and ate only what was given unasked; if nothing was given, he fasted. He felt neither hunger nor thirst, for the nectar of love sustained him, and he remained detached and indifferent to everything worldly (CC, Madhya 4.123–124, 4.180).

Grief for the World and the Meeting with Advaita

Happy in Krishna, Madhavendra suffered deeply to see people without devotion. Before Sri Chaitanya's appearance the world was bereft of love for Vishnu and sunk in passion and ignorance: people revelled in songs about Yogipala, Bhogipala and Mahipala, even sannyasis called themselves “Narayana,” and the “men of knowledge, yogis and ascetics” only argued and did not accept the form of Krishna (CB, Antya 4.416–436). He had no one to talk to, and he stopped speaking with sannyasis. “Better to go and live in the forest,” he decided; “there at least there is no talk with non-Vaishnavas.”

Day after day he thought of the good of the people, and his mind was turned to one thing: the descent of Krishna. Vrindavana Dasa shows how Madhavendra, seeing the wretched state of the world, longed ardently for Krishna to come, and on meeting Advaita passed on to Him the whole force of that longing.

So, grieving for the world, he came to Shantipur, to the house of Advaita Acharya. Advaita, who Himself grieved for the people, was then teaching the “Gita” and the “Bhagavatam,” revealing their meaning as devotion. Seeing in His guest the signs of a Vaishnava, He at once fell at his feet; Madhavendra embraced Him and bathed Him in tears. Absorbed in talk of Krishna, both forgot their bodies: at the sight of a cloud Madhavendra fell senseless, at the name of Krishna he roared. Advaita rejoiced to see such devotion to Vishnu and accepted instruction from him (CB, Antya 4.419–440).

Madhavendra, delighted by Advaita's love for Krishna, gave Him initiation into the mantra of Krishna, instruction and all that goes with them.[3] Advaita is Himself a manifestation of the Supreme Lord; and yet, convinced by His guest's ecstatic love that here was His guru, He underwent the rite of initiation to show conditioned souls that no one can do without a guru: He played the part of Madhavendra's disciple.[4]

Murari Gupta ("Kadacha" 1.4.5–6) names Madhava Puri the first of the associates who came to earth before the Lord: one portion of the Lord appeared in two ways — as him and as Advaita Acharya — and Chandrashekhara Acharyaratna became the disciple of them both. Advaita here is Maha-Vishnu Himself, and Madhavendra is His guru.

The "Chaitanya-bhagavata" (Antya 4.398) says that Madhavendra and Advaita are not different from each other, and yet Advaita is his disciple. That is why the Lord honoured Advaita as a guru, while Advaita Himself saw in Chaitanya the Lord and regarded Himself as His servant — His principal limb (CC, Adi 6.36–41).

At about the same time Madhavendra, with his disciple Sri Ranga Puri, a resident of Pandharpur, also visited Sridham Mayapur, the house of Jagannatha Mishra. Many years later Ranga Puri told the Lord in Pandharpur:

"They had taken their meal then in the house of Jagannatha Mishra, and he still remembered the indescribable taste of the banana-flower curry." (CC, Madhya 9.296)

"Jagannatha Mishra's wife had stayed in his memory as a deeply devoted and chaste woman. She showed them such care, as though she were the mother of the whole universe." (CC, Madhya 9.297)

Shachi fed the sannyasis as if they were her own sons. She and Jagannatha had a worthy son who took sannyasa under the name Shankararanya and attained perfection in Pandharpur.

The Meeting with Nityananda

Wandering as he pleased, together with disciples who relished the taste of love for Krishna, Madhavendra once met Nityananda by chance as the latter was touring the holy places of western India.[5] On seeing each other, both fell senseless and grew stunned with love; the disciples, led by Ishvara Puri, wept. Coming to themselves, the two embraced and rolled on the ground, roaring with love for Krishna; rivers of tears flowed from their eyes, and the earth thought itself blessed; trembling, tears, hair on end — "Chaitanya was playing in both their bodies," says the "Chaitanya-bhagavata" (Adi 9.158–168).

"However many holy places I have visited," said Nityananda, "only today have I gained their true fruit, in seeing your feet. Nowhere have I seen such love." And Madhavendra embraced Him, took Him on his lap and could not utter a word for tears — he only held Him to his breast.

Madhavendra's disciples — Ishvara Puri, Brahmananda Puri and others — at once came to love Nityananda. They had met many "sadhus" before, but found love for Krishna in none of them: all were seeking something else — the fruits of karma, knowledge, yoga, vows and austerities — and the disciples had wandered through the forests in sorrow. Now their grief vanished. Ishvara Puri, seeing how dear Nityananda was to his guru, was himself, like the others, filled with great love for Him.

For several days Nityananda wandered with Madhavendra, and through the forests they seemed to be enacting a search for Krishna. Neither knew day from night, the disciples sang the name of Hari unceasingly, and what the two spoke of only Krishna knows. "Nowhere have I seen such love," Madhavendra would say. "Where it is, there are all my holy places. Krishna is merciful to me, since He has given me such a friend. Where there is Nityananda's company, there are all the tirthas and

Vaikuntha itself. Whoever hears of such a devotee will surely attain Krishna; and whoever bears Nityananda even the slightest ill will is not dear to Krishna, even if he is a devotee.” So day and night he spoke of Nityananda and served Him with love (CB, Adi 9.169–185). Madhavendra treated Him as a friend and an equal, while Nityananda always honoured him only as His guru — for He, the teacher of all the world's teachers, was teaching people thus (CB, Adi 9.187–188; BR 5.2330–2334).

At last they parted: Nityananda went to Setubandha, Madhavendra to see the Sarayu. Both were so absorbed in Krishna that they did not remember their bodies — that is why they survived the separation; had they kept their outer consciousness, they could not have borne it (CB, Adi 9.189–192). In this mystery — of a life that does not break off even in unbearable separation — lies the foundation of Gaudiya Vaishnava dharma. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta explains that life is preserved because service gives an unbroken inner bliss; such love, in the words of the “Charitamrita,” is not to be found in the world of men (CC, Madhya 2.43). And whoever hears with faith the story of Nityananda and Madhavendra obtains the treasure of love for Krishna.

Whose disciple Nityananda Himself was, the traditions tell differently: some consider Him a disciple of Madhavendra, others of Lakshmipati Tirtha, and so Madhavendra's godbrother; the “Prema-vilasa” names Ishvara Puri as His guru.[6] Srila Bhaktisiddhanta, listing Madhavendra's principal disciples, names Ishvara Puri, Nityananda and Advaita.

Gopala on Govardhana

The main part of his story was preserved for us by Mahaprabhu Himself. Having accepted sannyasa at Katwa, He set out from Shantipur, from Advaita's house, for Puri — along the Ganga, through Chhatrabhoga, Atisara, Panihati and Baranagar, as far as Vriddha-mantreshvara on the border of Utkala. With Him were Nityananda, Mukunda Datta, Jagadananda and Damodara. This was in the month of Phalguna in the year 1431 of the Shaka era (1510), immediately after His sannyasa. At Remuna, in what is now Baleshvar district, before the Deity of Kshirachora-Gopinatha, the Lord told His companions about Madhavendra as He had heard it from His guru Ishvara Puri — and explained in passing how Gopinatha came by that name:

“In days of old this Deity stole sweet rice for Madhavendra Puri, and so became famous as ‘Kshira-chora Hari.’” (CC, Madhya 4.20)

Coming to Vraja, Madhavendra, intoxicated with love, circled Govardhana Hill, bathed in Govinda-kunda and towards evening sat down under a tree for his evening sandhya. A little cowherd boy came up to him, smiling, with a pot of milk. “What are you thinking about?” he asked. “Why don't you beg for food? Drink this milk.” The boy's beauty made Madhavendra forget both hunger and thirst. “Who are You?” he asked. “Where do You live? And how did You know I was fasting?” The boy answered that he was a cowherd from the village nearby, and that here no one goes hungry: some beg, some drink milk, and to those who do not beg he himself brings food. The women who had come to fetch water had noticed the stranger and sent the milk with him; now it was time for him to milk the cows, and he would come back for the pot later. And he vanished.

Madhavendra drank the milk, washed the pot and waited, chanting the holy names without closing his eyes. Only at the end of the night did a natural samadhi resembling sleep come over him, and he had a dream. The same boy took him by the hand, led him to a thicket and said: “I live here and endure cold, rain, wind and heat. Call the people of the village: let them take Me out, carry Me up to the top of the hill, build Me a temple and bathe Me with plenty of cool water. Long have I waited for you, thinking: when will Madhavendra come to serve Me?”

“Your love has conquered Me, and I wish to accept your service. Revealing Myself to the world, I shall grant everyone liberation from samsara.” (CC, Madhya 4.40)

“My name is Sri Gopala. I am the One who lifted Govardhana Hill. Krishna's grandson Vajra installed Me here. I am the true Lord of this holy abode.” (CC, Madhya 4.41)

Vajra, the son of Aniruddha and great-grandson of Krishna, had been brought from Dvaraka by the Pandavas and made king of Mathura. Later, Gopala said, the pujari who served Him, fearing a Muslim raid, hid Him in this thicket and fled — and here He had remained ever since.[7]

On waking, Madhavendra wept: “Krishna Himself came to me as a cowherd boy, and I did not recognise Him!” — and he rolled on the ground in love. Then, for the sake of the command, he composed himself, took his morning bath, gathered the villagers and told them that Govardhana-dhari, the lord of their village, lay hidden in the thicket and must be dug out. The people cleared the thicket and found a large Deity covered with earth and grass. They carried Him up to the summit and set Him on a great stone throne.[8] The brahmanas strained the water of Govinda-kunda and brought it in a hundred new pitchers; music sounded, people sang and danced, and the hill was covered with the villagers' offerings — ghee, milk, yoghurt and sweets.

Madhavendra performed the bathing ceremony (abhisheka) himself, according to every rule. He cleansed the body of the Deity with barley and wheat flour, lodhra powder, pistachios, saffron and pulse flour, with a brush of ushira grass and the hair of a cow's tail; he anointed Him with oil and bathed Him with panchagavya and panchamrita — first milk from a conch, then yoghurt, ghee, honey and sugar, each separately, as the “Hari-bhakti-vilasa” (6.30) enjoins — and finally with a hundred pitchers of water, in the great bath (maha-snana). For this, it is explained, ghee and water are taken in equal parts, about a hundred sers of water in all (a ser being roughly a litre); the “Hari-bhakti-vilasa” prescribes a hundred palas of water for a bath, twenty-five palas of oil, and two thousand palas for the maha-snana (a pala being about forty-five grams). Then the Deity was again anointed and bathed with fragrant sandalwood water from a conch, dried, dressed in fresh cloth and adorned with sandal paste, tulasi and garlands. Thus Madhavendra bathed Krishna and in every way gave himself to Him.

As Krishna at the end of the Dvapara-yuga told the cowherds to honour Govardhana with a mountain of food, so in the age of Kali Madhavendra had such a mountain prepared for Giridhari Gopala — the annakuta — from the provisions all the villagers had brought. Ten brahmanas cooked rice, five cooked vegetables, five or six baked flatbreads; around the mountain of rice were set pots of soups and vegetables, of milk, yoghurt and whey, of shikharini, sweet rice, butter and cream. Madhavendra offered all this together with pitchers of fragrant water, and Gopala, who had long gone hungry, ate everything — yet at the touch of His hands everything became as full as before:

“Sri Gopala ate all the offerings, touching them with His hand, but outwardly it was as if nothing had changed.” (CC, Madhya 4.77)

“Only Madhavendra Puri could see this, for the Lord has no secrets from His dear devotees.” (CC, Madhya 4.78)

The people marvelled at Puri's spiritual power: it was as if the ancient annakuta had come again. Then Gopala was offered water to rinse His mouth and betel, arati was performed and a new bed was prepared; and when He lay down to rest, Madhavendra distributed the prasada — first to the brahmanas, then to all the villagers. The news spread through the district, and village after village began to hold such feasts for Gopala:

“The residents of Vrindavana are always inclined to show their love for Sri Krishna, and Sri Krishna always returns their love.” (CC, Madhya 4.95)

Madhavendra made all the brahmanas Vaishnavas and gave each of them his own service. A wealthy kshatriya built a temple, others a kitchen, a storehouse and an enclosing wall;[9] every family of Vraja gave a cow, so that Gopala came to have ten thousand cows, and His worship became royal. In time two renunciant brahmanas came from Gauda; Madhavendra received them with care, made them his disciples and entrusted them with the service of Gopala. By his mercy, says the "Bhakti-ratnakara" (5.812–813), both were strong in renunciation and full of loving devotion. Thus Madhavendra founded a service by renunciants — not a hereditary service of householders passing from son to grandson. For two years he served Gopala himself.

So the Lord looks for a pretext to engage in service the devotee He longs for: Gopala had been waiting for Madhavendra. And in our own time, the biographers remark, the Deities of Jagadisha Pandita seemed of Their own accord to "offer Themselves" to Bhakti Dayita Madhava Maharaja.

For Sandalwood: Remuna and Puri

Two years later Gopala came again in a dream. He felt hot in the summer heat, He said; let Madhavendra anoint Him with Malaya sandalwood — the kind called "malayaja," because its home is Malaya: the Malabar coast, the mountains of the Western Ghats and the Nilgiris. "Go yourself, at once, to Nilachala and bring the sandalwood: it cannot be done through anyone else." Delighted by the direct command, Madhavendra entrusted the service to a worthy man and immediately set out east, to Gauda, on the road to Puri. On the way he stopped at Shantipur, at Advaita's house, and from there went south and came to Remuna.

On seeing the beautiful Gopinatha, Madhavendra sang and danced with love. Delighted with the worship, he asked the brahmana servitor what was offered to the Deity — so that he might offer the same to his Gopala. The man replied: in the evening, twelve pots of amrita-keli, thick sweetened milk famed everywhere as "Gopinatha's kshira," and there is none better in the world. Madhavendra wished to taste a little of this kshira without asking, so as later to prepare the same for Gopala. But at once he felt ashamed: this was a whim of the tongue, an offence — and he began to remember Vishnu. After watching the arati he left and sat down in the deserted marketplace of the village, chanting the holy names.

Meanwhile the pujari put Gopinatha to rest and lay down himself. In a dream the Deity told him to rise and open the temple doors: behind the folds of His garment was hidden a pot of kshira for a sannyasi named Madhava Puri, who was sitting in the market; and how He had set it aside the pujari had not noticed, by the will of His yogamaya.[10] The pujari found the kshira where Gopinatha had said and went through the market calling out loudly:

"With the pot of sweet rice in his hands the pujari cried: 'Madhavendra Puri, answer! Sri Gopinatha Himself has stolen this pot for you!'" (CC, Madhya 4.133)

"'Take this pot and enjoy the sweet rice. Truly, there is no one more fortunate than you in the whole universe!'" (CC, Madhya 4.134)

Madhavendra made himself known. The pujari gave him the kshira, fell at his feet and told him everything; he understood that before him was the greatest of devotees, one who holds Krishna in his power. And love overwhelmed Madhavendra. He reverently ate the prasada — to the joy of both Gopinatha and Gopala — washed the clay pot, broke it into pieces, tied them in the corner of his upper cloth, and afterwards ate one piece every day, each time sinking again into love. Ever since, Gopinatha has been called Kshirachora — "he who stole the kshira."

He knew that by morning the news would spread and crowds would come. Fearing fame, he bowed to Gopinatha and left for Puri before dawn. But his fame outran him: on seeing Jagannatha he was filled

with love, while people who had already heard of the miracle came to him in a stream to pay their respects.

“Throughout the world the wayward nature of fame is well known. Even if someone does not desire it, by the grace of providence it sometimes comes to him of itself.” (CC, Madhya 4.146)

“Dreading the honour of all, Sri Madhavendra Puri left Remuna. But fame followed him, born of his pure love for Krishna.” (CC, Madhya 4.147)

Fame comes of itself to one who has love for God, even if he runs from it.

He could not leave Puri: first he had to keep his promise. He told the servitors and managers of Jagannatha's temple about the sandalwood, and those who had connections with the king obtained, through the king's men, sandalwood and camphor — the very camphor used in Jagannatha's arati. They gave him a brahmana and a servant to help him and money for the road, and the king gave him a letter exempting him from tolls at the river crossings. He carried one maund of sandalwood and about twenty tolas of camphor, and the road ran through Muslim lands, past countless toll-posts, while he had not a single coin. The toll-collectors of Orissa detained him but let him pass on the strength of the king's letter. Covering a thousand kroshas on this errand, he gave no thought to the hardships — he only rejoiced that he would anoint Gopala (CC, Madhya 4.176–186):

“Such is the natural conduct of one who possesses selfless devotion to God: he does not think of his own comfort, and no difficulties or sufferings ever trouble him.” (CC, Madhya 4.186)

“And to show people the depth of Madhavendra Puri's divine love, Sri Gopala ordered him to bring sandalwood and camphor from Jagannatha Puri.” (CC, Madhya 4.187)

Gopala gave this order to show the world his love and to test him. He knew how hard it was to carry sandalwood through Muslim lands, and by accepting it He made His devotee's labour fruitful: having tested him, He showed His mercy. Deep love takes no account of its own toil.

On the way back, at Remuna, Madhavendra again sang and danced before Gopinatha, took the prasada of kshira and spent the night in the temple. Towards morning Gopala appeared to him in a dream: “Madhava, I have already received all the sandalwood and camphor. Grind the sandalwood with the camphor and anoint Gopinatha: His body and Mine are one, and this will cool Me too. Do not hesitate.” Madhavendra passed the command on to Gopinatha's servitors; they rejoiced, for it was the height of the heat. Two of his companions and two of the temple's men ground sandalwood every day, and Madhavendra stayed in Remuna the whole summer, until the sandalwood was used up. When the rains began he returned to Puri and spent the chaturmasya there.

Having finished this story, Mahaprabhu asked Nityananda:

“‘O Nityananda,’ the Lord asked, ‘what do you think — could anyone in this world be more fortunate than Madhavendra Puri?’” (CC, Madhya 4.171)

“Krishna Himself appeared before him, giving him a pot of milk. Three times, too, He came to him in dreams and gave him direct instructions.” (CC, Madhya 4.172)

“Conquered by his pure love, Sri Krishna appeared as Sri Gopala and, accepting his service, delivered the whole world.” (CC, Madhya 4.173)

“For his sake Sri Gopinatha stole sweet rice, becoming known after that as the Deity ‘Kshira-chora Gopinatha.’” (CC, Madhya 4.174)

And the Lord stressed further that Madhavendra had gone the whole way without a second companion:

“He was supremely detached, silent and indifferent to everything. Fearing talk of worldly things, he always lived alone.” (CC, Madhya 4.179)

Disciples and Followers

Among Madhavendra's disciples the biographies, drawing on the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” and the “Charitamrita,” name Ishvara Puri, Advaita Acharya, Nityananda (a disputed point, as we have seen), Pundarika Vidyanidhi, Paramananda Puri, Sri Ranga Puri, the Sanodiya brahmana, Raghupati Upadhyaya, Keshava Bharati, Brahmananda Puri and Brahmananda Bharati, Keshava Puri, Krishnananda Puri, Nrisimha Tirtha, Sukhananda Puri and Ramachandra Puri.

The dearest of them, in Srila Bhaktisiddhanta's words, was Ishvara Puri, a brahmana from Kumarahatta. He received initiation and sannyasa from Madhavendra and gave himself wholly to the service of his guru; by the time of the meeting with Nityananda he was already his teacher's first servant and constant companion. Mahaprabhu accepted him as His guru, says Srila Bhaktisiddhanta, in order to reveal his glory.

Paramananda Puri, a brahmana from Tirhut, likewise received initiation from Madhavendra; the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Antya 3.178) calls him a dear disciple of Madhava Puri, full of the taste of divine love. For this reason Mahaprabhu honoured him as a dear elder, and on first seeing him exclaimed, “Today My sannyasa is fulfilled — it is as if Madhavendra himself has appeared to Me!” (CB, Antya 3.168–175). Later, at the devotees' request, it was he who interceded with the Lord on behalf of Chhota Haridasa. In the tree of devotion of the “Charitamrita” he is the middle one of the nine roots; the other roots are Keshava Bharati, Brahmananda Puri, Brahmananda Bharati, Vishnu Puri, Keshava Puri, Krishnananda Puri, Nrisimha Tirtha and Sukhananda Puri — and above them are the first sprout, Madhavendra, the second, Ishvara Puri, and the trunk, Mahaprabhu (CC, Adi 9.13–16).

Mahaprabhu met Sri Ranga Puri in Pandharpur, in the house of a brahmana where he was staying, and fell at his feet in love:

“Seeing Sri Chaitanya before him offering dandavat, Sri Ranga Puri was amazed and exclaimed: ‘O Shripada, please rise!’” (CC, Madhya 9.288)

“‘O Shripada! You are surely connected with my teacher, Sri Madhavendra Puri. Were it not so, there would not be even a particle of such divine love in You.’” (CC, Madhya 9.289)

Learning that the Lord was a disciple of Ishvara Puri, Ranga Puri was filled with tenderness towards Him, and for seven days they spoke of Krishna. From him the Lord first heard that Shankararanya, Vishvarupa, had attained perfection right there in Pandharpur. Then Ranga Puri left for Dvaraka; it is said that later, when the Lord returned from the south, they met again, and Ranga Puri spent the rest of his life with Him in Purushottama-kshetra.

Pundarika Vidyanidhi, the guru of Gadadhara Pandita, was also a disciple of Madhavendra; he is believed to have received initiation at the same time as Advaita. Mahaprabhu always honoured him as Madhavendra's disciple, a godbrother of His own guru (GGD 56; “Prema-vilasa” 22).

In Mathura Madhavendra came to the house of the Sanodiya brahmana, gave him the mantra and accepted a meal from him. This brahmana came from a family of priests of the Sanvar caste, associated with goldsmiths. Bhaktivinoda Thakura explains that among the western vaishyas the Agravals are considered pure, while the Kanvars and Sanvars are considered fallen; their priests are called Sanodiya brahmanas, and sannyasis do not eat at their houses. But Madhavendra, seeing in him a Vaishnava, accepted food from him — and thereby showed what daiva-varnashrama is: a Vaishnava is not judged by caste. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta calls the Sanodiya brahmana a pure devotee: although by caste rules it

was forbidden to drink water from his hands, he stood on daiva-varnashrama, and those who judge devotees by worldly caste or despise maha-prasada the Lord called wicked fools.

By Madhavendra's mercy love for Krishna awoke in this brahmana. Many years later, already an old man, he saw the Lord dancing in ecstasy in Mathura, at the temple of Keshavaji, fell at His feet and joined in His dance; the people, seeing such love, decided that before them was an incarnation of Krishna, while the brahmana recognised in Him the son of the king of Vraja and understood at once that He was connected with Madhavendra. In private Mahaprabhu called him a venerable, simple-hearted old brahmana and asked him where he had obtained such a treasure:

“The brahmana answered: ‘Once the venerable Shripada Sri Madhavendra Puri came to Mathura during his pilgrimage.’” (CC, Madhya 17.166)

By his causeless mercy Madhavendra came to his house, accepted him as a disciple and even consented to dine with him (CC, Madhya 17.167).

“‘Then Sri Gopala revealed Himself to the world, and Madhavendra Puri established His worship. From that day this Deity has been served on Govardhana Hill.’” (CC, Madhya 17.168)

Hearing this, the Lord, as before a godbrother of His guru, bowed down at his feet: “You are My guru, I am your disciple, and it is not fitting for a guru to bow to his disciple.” And the brahmana replied that such love does not exist without a connection with Madhavendra: without him there is not even a scent of it (CC, Madhya 17.170–173). He asked Balabhadra Bhattacharya the name of the Lord's guru and rejoiced; the Lord accepted bhiksha from him. The Sanodiya brahmana became His companion in His circuit of the twelve forests of Vraja and, together with Balabhadra, considered how to lead the Lord on to Soro-kshetra and Prayaga.

Raghupati Upadhyaya of Tirhut, Mithila, a famous scholar, was also a disciple of Madhavendra (according to the “Gaudiya-bhashya” on CB, Adi 9.154); his verses are included in the “Padyavali” (99, 127). In Prayaga, in the presence of Vallabha Bhatta, he met the Lord, recognised Him as Krishna and spoke with Him about the degrees of excellence (CC, Madhya 19.99–100).

Keshava Bharati, of the Bharati order going back to Shankara, head of the matha in Katwa — the one who gave sannyasa to Nimai[11] — was, in the opinion of some, a mantra-disciple of Madhavendra and a Vaishnava sannyasi. Brahmananda Puri is called by some an initiated disciple of Madhavendra, by others his follower; he was present at the meeting with Nityananda. Brahmananda Bharati, and also Keshava Puri, Krishnananda Puri, Nrisimha Tirtha and Sukhananda Puri, are among the nine sannyasis who followed Madhavendra; according to the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” (97–100), they belong to the eight siddhas and nine Yogendras. Some call Keshava Puri the elder brother of Vallabhacharya, but this report has not been verified.

Through his disciple's disciple Madhavendra is connected with Ramananda Raya as well: according to the “Bhajana-nirnaya,” Ramananda was a disciple of Raghavendra Puri and thus a disciple of Madhavendra's disciple. With Vallabhacharya (Vallabha Bhatta) he is linked by a chain of teachers: Vallabha was a disciple of Gadadhara Pandita, Gadadhara of Pundarika, and Pundarika of Madhavendra. According to the “Nij-varta,” in early childhood Vallabha studied the Vedas with Madhavendra in Kashi, and the “Vallabha-digvijaya” calls Madhavendra his teacher in the Vaishnava scriptures. Sanatana Gosvami, in the auspicious opening verses of his work, honours “Sri Madhava Puri, king of sannyasis, surrounded by disciples, through whom the immortal tree of devotion to Krishna sprouted in the world.”

Among those who called themselves his disciples was also Ramachandra Puri. Where he came from is unknown. Formally he was a sannyasi of one of the ten orders of Shankara; he inclined to dry

knowledge and the philosophy of Mayavada — a disciple in appearance only. The Lord and Paramananda Puri honoured him as a disciple of Madhavendra, and in Benares Mahaprabhu announced that He was staying with him so as to avoid reproach. What came of his discipleship is seen in Madhavendra's last days.

Departure

Towards the end of his life Madhavendra grew weak and could no longer move. He chanted the names of Krishna and wept, for he was in deep separation — in the mood of Radha after Krishna's departure for Mathura. Like every pure devotee, he felt that he had not obtained Krishna's mercy, because he had not become worthy of it.

“When his teacher, the great saint Madhavendra Puri, was on the point of death, Ramachandra Puri came to see him.” (CC, Antya 8.16)

“Madhavendra Puri ceaselessly chanted the holy name of Krishna. At times he prayed with tears in his eyes: ‘O my Lord, I have never attained shelter in Mathura.’” (CC, Antya 8.17)

“Then Ramachandra Puri foolishly instructed him. Without a trace of shame or fear he addressed his teacher:” (CC, Antya 8.18)

“‘You are full of spiritual bliss and should always remember Brahman alone. For if you have realised Brahman, what could make you weep?’” (CC, Antya 8.19)

Madhavendra grew angry: “Away, away, you sinner! I am dying of grief that I have not obtained Krishna's mercy and have not reached Mathura, and you have come to add to my torment. Do not show me your face, go wherever you like: if I die looking at you, an evil destination awaits me. This fool is teaching me about Brahman!” (CC, Antya 8.20–23).

“Thus Madhavendra Puri rejected his disciple Ramachandra Puri. This offence against his teacher awakened in Ramachandra Puri a multitude of worldly desires.” (CC, Antya 8.24)

“Dry, detached realisation of the Absolute does not develop a person's spiritual relationship with Krishna. On the contrary, such an impersonalist philosopher soon becomes attached to offences and begins to criticise everyone indiscriminately.” (CC, Antya 8.25)

Ramachandra reviled everyone, and everyone reviled him. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta explains in the “Anubhashya” that Ramachandra did not recognise the transcendental nature of his guru's separation; he took him for an ordinary man and his feeling for a worldly one, born of some lack, and set about teaching him the oneness of Brahman. Seeing his disciple's foolishness and disrespect, Madhavendra ceased to wish him well and drove him away. The “worldly desires” here are the craving for dry knowledge, from which grows the tendency to revile devotees. Such is the fruit of disregard for the guru: step by step the offence reaches even the Lord Himself (CC, Antya 8.97–98) — later Ramachandra reviled Mahaprabhu too: finding no fault in Him, he noticed a line of ants in His room, suspected that the Lord had been eating sweets and slandered Him — and fell, as every reviler of the guru and the Vaishnavas falls.

Quite differently did Ishvara Puri serve his teacher:

“Whereas another of his disciples, Ishvara Puri (the teacher of Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu), personally tended Madhavendra Puri, cleaning away his urine and stool with his own hands.” (CC, Antya 8.26)

“Ishvara Puri constantly helped his teacher to remember Krishna, telling of Krishna's lilas and chanting His holy name.” (CC, Antya 8.27)

“Fully satisfied with Ishvara Puri, Madhavendra Puri embraced him and blessed him: ‘May you obtain all the wealth of divine love for Krishna.’” (CC, Antya 8.28)

Of all the disciples he served best. Srila Bhaktivedanta Swami remarks that perfection is attained by the guru's mercy, and the apparent infirmity of a Vaishnava only gives his disciples an opportunity to serve.

“Thus Ishvara Puri became like an ocean of love for Krishna, whereas Ramachandra Puri became an inveterate critic.” (CC, Antya 8.29)

“Thus these two disciples became evidence of the results of the blessing and the rejection of a true saint. Through them Madhavendra Puri taught a lesson to the people of the whole world.” (CC, Antya 8.30)

One who pleases a great soul becomes an ocean of love; one who angers him becomes a reviler. A disciple who satisfies his guru obtains every good, while the guru's displeasure brings only misfortune.

Bestowing love for Krishna on the world, Madhavendra Puri, the teacher of the whole world, departed with a single verse on his lips:

ayi dīna-dayārdra nātha he mathurā-nātha kadāvalokyase hṛdayaṁ tvad-aloka-kātaraṁ dayita bhrāmyati kiṁ karomy aham

“O Lord, whose heart melts with pity for the wretched! O Lord of Mathura, when shall I see You? Not seeing You, my heart wanders in anguish. Beloved, what am I to do?” (CC, Antya 8.32)

“With this verse Madhavendra Puri teaches us all how we may obtain pure love for Krishna. Only acute separation from Krishna can raise a devotee to the level of this sacred love.” (CC, Antya 8.33)

“Before his departure Madhavendra Puri planted in this world the seed of unalloyed love for Krishna. Soon that seed became the glorious tree named Chaitanya Mahaprabhu.” (CC, Antya 8.34)

With this verse, the “Charitamrita” says in another place too (Madhya 4.196), Madhavendra attained perfection at the end of his life. His day of departure is honoured on the twelfth lunar day of the bright fortnight of Phalguna — Govinda in the Vaishnava calendar (phalguna shukla-dvadashi).[12] Where it took place the “Charitamrita” does not say.[13] All that is clear is that by Phalguna of 1431 Shaka, when Mahaprabhu told of him in Remuna, Madhavendra had already withdrawn from the eyes of the world.[14]

The Day of Remembrance in Advaita's House

Every year Advaita Acharya celebrated the day of remembrance of His guru (CB, Antya 4.441–468).[15] Once this day fell at the time when the Lord, already a sannyasi, was staying with Him at Shantipur (CB, Antya 4.396–397). Advaita joyfully spent all He had, and provisions poured in from every side. Gaurasundara with all His companions was happy. Ai — Shachi — together with the wives of the Vaishnavas took on all the cooking, Nityananda the reception and honouring of the Vaishnavas; some ground sandalwood, others wove garlands, carried water, swept the courtyard, washed the guests' feet, hung up flags and canopies; the sankirtana never ceased, and Advaita's house became Vaikuntha.

The Lord went round the storerooms and inspected the provisions: rooms full of rice, mountains of food, pots, mung beans, cloth, leaf-plates, chira, thousands of bunches of bananas, coconuts, betel, vegetables, thousands of pots of yoghurt and milk, oil, salt and ghee. All the Vaishnavas, anointed with sandal paste and wearing garlands, sang and danced. Nityananda danced like a child, Advaita and Haridasa without tiring, and at last the Lord stood everyone in a circle and Himself danced in the middle. Then all sat down to the meal; the Lord sat in the centre, “like ten million moons among the stars,” and spoke all the time of Madhava Puri: “Whoever eats here on the day of Madhavendra's worship obtains devotion to Govinda” (CB, Antya 4.492–508).

Madhavendra's Verses

Rupa Gosvami preserved five of Madhavendra's verses in the “Padyavali.” In one (79) he takes leave of his former duties: “Farewell, sandhya-vandana! Obeisances to you, ritual baths! Gods and forefathers, forgive me: I can no longer offer you libations. Wherever I sit, I remember the Enemy of Kamsa, the ornament of the Yadu dynasty — and that, I think, is enough.” In another (96) he prays that there may appear in his mind that cowherd boy, expert in the games of love, who longs for the rasa dance with the maidens of Vraja. The third (104) is a sigh: “When shall I see the son of Nanda, with a garland of kadamba flowers and tilaka on His brow?” In the fourth (286) sounds the flute of Hari, full of the sweetness of the nectar of His lips: it delights the deer, the doe-eyed maidens and the sages. The fifth (330) is “ayi dīna-dayārdra nātha,” the very verse that the “Charitamrita” quotes twice (Madhya 4.197 and Antya 8.32).

At Remuna, having told His companions about Madhavendra, Mahaprabhu Himself recited this verse — and became so intoxicated with love that Nityananda had to catch Him and hold Him up (CC, Madhya 4.197–199). Before that, He spoke of the verse thus:

“As the fragrance of Malaya sandalwood grows stronger with rubbing, so the meaning of this verse, when one reflects on it, begins to shine with ever new facets.” (CC, Madhya 4.192)

“As the Kaustubha gem is acknowledged the best of precious stones, so this verse is the best in the poetic description of the divine rasas.” (CC, Madhya 4.193)

“This verse was spoken by Srimati Radharani Herself, and by Her mercy it came forth from the lips of Sri Madhavendra Puri.” (CC, Madhya 4.194)

“Sri Chaitanya could relish its secret meaning in full. A fourth who could do so simply does not exist.” (CC, Madhya 4.195)

Bhaktivinoda Thakura explains where the power of this verse lies. The best way to worship Krishna is to follow the mood of Radhika's great love in separation, after His departure for Mathura. A devotee of this taste, considering himself insignificant, calls out to the “Lord merciful to the wretched”; the feeling of separation is the natural bhajana of the soul. It is akin to Radha's feelings on seeing Uddhava, revealed in Mahaprabhu.

A Sanskrit hymn, the “Yugalashtakam,” is also ascribed to Madhavendra: a manuscript of it, one leaf in Bengali script, is kept at the Bangiya Sahitya Parishad in Calcutta (no. 513 in its catalogue of Sanskrit manuscripts).

Gopala after Madhavendra: Shrinathji

The Gopala revealed by Madhavendra was also called Sri Govardhana-natha, the Lord of Govardhana; in time He became famous as Sri Govardhananathji, or Shrinathji for short. Under this name He is served by the descendants and followers of Vallabhacharya, whereas the Gaudiya authors call Him, as Madhavendra did, Gopala. He is that very two-armed Krishna of Madhavendra of the Madhva sampradaya; under the authority of Vallabha's son He was taken away from Mathura-mandala, and today, in the hills of Rajasthan, the Vallabha sampradaya serves Him with great splendour. His history after Madhavendra is long and tangled; the Gaudiya and Vallabhite traditions tell it differently, and both sides are given below.

Gopala in Mahaprabhu's Day

It is said that in 1498 the henchmen of Sikandar Lodi began to persecute the temples of Vishnu in Vraja. The Gaudiya pujaris then carried Gopala off to the dense forest of Taker-ghona, some three miles away, and served Him there in secret — of this, tradition says, Kumbhandasa sings: “You love the dense forest of Tonda.” When Lodi's men, having ravaged the temple on Govardhana, had gone, Gopala was moved

to Shyamadhak, about a mile from Giriraja, and served in a grass hut. There Vallabhacharya saw Him and, it is said, on the second lunar day of the bright fortnight of Chaitra 1499 installed Him again on Giriraja.

Vallabhacharya, who had previously worshipped with the mantra of Bala-Gopala, received by the mercy of Gadadhara Pandita initiation into the mantra of Kishora-Gopala (CC, Antya 7.144–145). In 1434 or 1435 of the Shaka era (1512–1513) Mahaprabhu came to Arail, where Rupa and his brother Vallabha (Anupama), the father of Jiva, were then living, and showed His mercy to Vallabhacharya; Vallabha with his whole family drank the water that had washed the Lord's feet. His elder son Gopinatha, born in 1432 Shaka (1510), was then two or three years old, while the younger, Vitthala, was not yet born: he came into the world in 1437 Shaka (1515), as Srila Bhaktisiddhanta also states in the “Anubhashya” (on CC, Madhya 18.47 and 19.108). According to another account, both sons were small, and Vallabha laid them at the Lord's feet (CC, Madhya 19.84–112). Vitthalanatha's horoscope, cast by Govindasvami, gives a Friday, the ninth lunar day of the dark fortnight of Pausha, 21 dandas 25 palas, the year 1572 of the Vikrama era — 1437 Shaka, 1515; the Vallabhite author Televala writes that he was born at Charanat near Allahabad and spent his childhood at Adel.[16]

Coming to Vraja, Mahaprabhu, after Radha-kunda and the darshana of Harideva, wished to see Gopala, but He had vowed not to climb Govardhana. Then Gopala, “as if out of fear of the Muslims,” came to Him Himself. A rumour of a Pathan raid spread through Anor, and the Gaudiya pujaris at once carried Gopala off to Gathuli, to a spot above Gulala-kunda, then dense forest, and served Him in secret; Mahaprabhu, who had come from Nilachala, received His darshana just at that time. For three days Gopala stayed above the kunda, and on the fourth, seeing that no raid came, the pujaris returned Him to the temple on Giriraja. He was then served by two Bengali brahmanas, disciples of Madhavendra (BR 5.812–813). Gopala displayed this lila — the move to Gathuli — later as well; Sanatana Gosvami too saw Him there.

Having received the mercy of Gaurasundara and Gadadhara Pandita, Vallabhacharya completely restored Gopala's temple on Govardhana and on the third lunar day of the bright fortnight of Vaishakha 1441 Shaka (1519), amid sankirtana, installed Gopala in it; below, at the foot of the hill, he built himself a hut for bhajana. Vallabha's followers tell of the new temple in more detail. According to the “Nij-varta,” on the night before the second lunar day of the bright fortnight of Chaitra 1556 of the Vikrama era (1499) Govardhana-natha commanded in a dream a wealthy kshatriya Rajput, Puranmal of Ambala, to build a great temple. Puranmal went in search of the Deity installed by Vajranabha and found through a dream by Madhavendra, and found Him on Giriraja; He was then served by Ramadasa Chauhan, and Sadu Pande, the headman of Anor, told him to wait for Vallabhacharya. Through a dream an architect from Agra, Hiramani, came as well; the foundation was laid on a Sunday, the third lunar day of the bright fortnight of Vaishakha, under the nakshatra Rohini, in 1556 Vikrama, and twenty years later, in 1576 Vikrama (1441 Shaka, 1519), Vallabha installed the Deity in the new temple.[17] Yadunatha's “Vallabha-digvijaya,” in the section on Vallabha's third journey, likewise says that the merchant Puranmal, at the Lord's command, became the acharya's disciple, began digging the foundation on the bright tritiya of the month of Madhava, and on the Vaishakha tritiya Govardhana-dhara was installed in the new temple.

Krishnadasa and the Expulsion of the Bengalis

Vallabhacharya entrusted the management of the temple to his disciple Krishnadasa, a shudra from Gujarat, seeing his practical ability. Vallabha himself at the end of his life passed through all the stages of sannyasa — kutichaka, bahudaka, hamsa and paramahamsa — and, having taken sannyasa thirty-nine days before his departure, left the world in 1587 of the Vikrama era (1452 Shaka, 1530).

After his departure Vallabha's sons, Gopinatha and Vitthalanatha, confirmed Krishnadasa as manager of the temple and returned to Adail. Krishnadasa appointed a Gujarati brahmana, Ramadasa Chauhan, as pujari. Ten years after Vallabha's departure Gopinatha went to Puri; his son Purushottamji died young, and Vallabha's seat passed to Vitthalanatha.

Krishnadasa, however, wanted sole power over the temple. The Gaudiya pujaris, following the precept of their guru Madhavendra, gave away all of Gopala's prasada and wealth, hoarding nothing, while Krishnadasa wanted to accumulate. He became attached to a dancer, Gangabai, brought a dancing girl from Agra and tried to replace the Vaishnava kirtana at Gopala's awakening with her singing and dancing. Krishnadasa went to Adail (Arail) to Vitthalanatha, Vallabha's son, who was the patron of the Gaudiya pujaris, and turned his mind; it is said that Vitthalanatha believed him and wrote to Raja Todarmal and Birbal asking them to help him. Then Krishnadasa gathered bad men in Mathura and, while the pujaris were serving on Govardhana, set fire to their houses above Rudra-kunda — the whole village burned down; he seized the temple and drove out and wounded the pujaris with sticks. He very nearly closed the temple even to Vitthalanatha himself.

The pujaris went to Vrindavana, to Rupa and Sanatana, who were then living in burning separation from Gaura, and then to the royal court in Mathura; but Krishnadasa bribed the officials. Rupa and Sanatana, hearing that the service of Gopala, the treasure of Madhavendra's heart, might pass to royal officials, handed the service and the temple over to Vitthalanatha and duly provided for the Gaudiya pujaris. The “Bhakti-ratnakara” (5.814–817) puts it thus: when the two brahmanas, Madhavendra's disciples, were no more, a certain fortunate man served for a while, and then, after consultation with Dasa Gosvami and others, the right of service was given to Vitthaleshvara — who after his father's departure lived in seclusion in Mathura, was deeply moved by the lilas of Gaurachandra and always served Gopala with zeal. The Gosvamis headed by Rupa and Raghunatha approved his service because he acknowledged the authority of Krishna Chaitanya and His companions.

The Vallabhite “Chaurasi Vaishnavan ki Varta” of Gokulanatha tells the same story differently. At first Shrinathji was served by Bengalis, and Vallabhacharya appointed Krishnadasa as manager. Krishnadasa was incited to expel the Bengalis by Avadhuta Dasa,[18] to whom Shrinathji Himself supposedly complained that the Bengalis were troubling Him by secretly offering food first to a little goddess hidden in a knot of hair. Vitthalanatha said that within a year the Bengalis had carried off to their guru nearly a lakh of rupees collected in the east for ornaments, but after all it was the Acharyaji himself who had appointed them. Krishnadasa obtained letters to Todarmal and Birbal, set fire to the Bengalis' huts at Rudra-kunda and beat them with a stick. Rupa and Sanatana kept silent: “You know, and He knows.” The judge of Mathura ordered that the Bengalis be left alone, but Krishnadasa refused, citing Vitthalanatha, and Vitthalanatha told the Bengalis: “You abandoned the service when your houses were burning — the fault is yours.”

The same varta relates that Krishnadasa became infatuated with a courtesan in Agra and brought her to Nathdvara, and at the Lord's awakening she sang instead of the kirtaniyas. Once Gangabai glanced at the offering, and the service could not take place; Shrinathji told the servitor, “I have not eaten,” and Vitthalanatha himself cooked and offered Him food. Krishnadasa forbade Vitthalanatha to climb up to the temple, and Birbal imprisoned Krishnadasa, but Vitthalanatha refused to eat until he saw him, and he was released. Krishnadasa's end was not a happy one: given three hundred rupees for a well, he buried a hundred under a tree, and while inspecting the finished well he slipped, fell into it and died. “The tamasic go downwards,” said Ramadasa. This happened soon after 1567.

Televala, himself a follower of the Pushtimarga, writes that while Madhavendra lived there were no disputes: the service was conducted by Bengali Vaishnavas under the supervision of Krishnadasa Adhikari. Gopinatha brought about a lakh of rupees from Gujarat, and under Vitthaleshvara wealthy

Gujaratis brought gifts; the Bengalis supposedly carried these off secretly to their gosvamis in Vrindavana. A certain Anantadasa rose up against this, and Krishnadasa, with a letter to Birbal, set fire to the Bengalis' huts. Akbar by a firman granted Vitthaleshvara the village of Jatipura; the inner service was restricted to his kinsmen, and of the brahmanas only Girnaras and Sachoras were admitted. It was then, Televala concludes, that Vitthaleshvara lost the traces of the “thought of Chaitanya” he had acquired at Jagannatha Puri in 1616 of the Vikrama era.

Mathura and Satghara

In 1562 Akbar's soldiers attacked Adail. Vitthalanatha withdrew to Bandhogarh, then to Garha, where Queen Durgavati honoured him, and in 1565 moved to Vraja, to Gokula, to land bought long before by Vallabha. After a dispute with the zamindar of Mahavana he moved to Satghara in Mathura — north of Holi Gate (Harding Gate), on the way to Vishrama-ghata through Tulasi-chabutara. “Satghara” means “the houses of the seven brothers”: Durgavati built them for the seven sons of Vitthaleshvara — Giridhara, Govinda, Balakrishna, Gokulanatha, Raghunatha, Yadunatha and Ghanashyama.

Leaving the house in the care of his eldest son, Giridhara, Vitthalanatha went to Govardhana to Gopala, was grieved by Krishnadasa's outrages and forbade them. Giridhara, who was close to Birbal, with the help of the royal officials of Mathura moved Gopala to his own house in Satghara: according to Televala, Shrinathji was brought there from Govardhana on the seventh lunar day of the dark fortnight of Phalguna 1623 of the Vikrama era (early 1567) for nearly two months.

Hearing that Gopala was in Mathura, Rupa Gosvami came with his companions from Vrindavana and stayed a whole month in Mathura, in Vitthala's house at Satghara, beholding Gopala:[19]

“Sri Rupa with his companions also spent a whole month in Mathura, beholding this Deity.” (CC, Madhya 18.48)

“He was accompanied by Gopala Bhatta Gosvami, Raghunatha Dasa Gosvami, Raghunatha Bhatta Gosvami and Lokanatha Dasa Gosvami.” (CC, Madhya 18.49)

“Bhugarbha Gosvami, Sri Jiva Gosvami, Sri Yadava Acharya and Govinda Gosvami.” (CC, Madhya 18.50)

“Sri Uddhava Dasa, Madhava, Sri Gopala Dasa and Narayana Dasa.” (CC, Madhya 18.51)

“Also the great devotee Govinda, Vani Krishnadasa, Pundarikaksha, Ishana and Laghu Haridasa.” (CC, Madhya 18.52)

“After a month Sri Gopala went to His temple, and Sri Rupa Gosvami returned to Vrindavana.” (CC, Madhya 18.54)

Rupa and his companions were so delighted with Vitthalanatha's service that they lived with him for a month; Raghunatha Dasa praised this service of Gopala in the “Gopala-raja-stotra” (13–14). Later, according to the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (5.798–806), Raghava Pandita brought Srinivasa and Narottama to Gathuli: they saw Gopala and the Deity of Krishna Chaitanya served by Vitthala, and Vitthalanatha, Vallabha's son, received them with indescribable love. Vitthaleshvara's house in Satghara, where Rupa saw Gopala, and the places of service of his seven sons were later destroyed by men of another faith.

On the fourth lunar day of the bright fortnight of Vaishakha 1567 (974 of the Bengali era) Gopala, at Vitthalanatha's direction, was returned to the temple on Govardhana. Vitthalanatha himself departed on the seventh lunar day of the dark fortnight of Magha 1642 of the Vikrama era (1507 Shaka, 1585; 991 of the Bengali era). After him his seven sons declared themselves the sevaits of Gopala and introduced a new order of worship, contrary to the views and customs both of Madhavendra and of the Gosvamis headed by Rupa.

The Road to Nathdvara

In 1668 Aurangzeb began to persecute the temples of Vishnu in Vraja, and Vallabha's descendants, with the help of the Vrajavasis, secretly carried Gopala away in a bullock cart on the full-moon day of Ashvina. His road was long — through Agra, Kota, Bundi, Jodhpur, Chapa, Seni and Krishnagarh to Sinhar in the dominions of Udaipur. There Rana Sujan Singh built Him a temple and granted lands, and around the temple grew a town — Shrinatha-dvara, Nathdvara. In 1801, when Holkar of Indore attacked Nathdvara, Shrinathji was taken to Ghasiyar, and in 1807 brought back to Shrinatha-dvara, where Gopala, the treasure of Madhavendra's heart and the Lord of the Gaudiyas, resides to this day.

In brief, Gopala's wanderings were these: - Govardhana: Madhavendra finds Gopala in the thicket and installs Him on the hill. - 1498–1499: for fear of Sikandar Lodi's men — the forest of Taker-ghona, then Shyamadhak; in 1499 — back on Giriraja. - In Mahaprabhu's day: three days at Gathuli, above Gulala-kunda. - 1519: the new temple on Govardhana, consecrated by Vallabhacharya. - 1567: about two months at Satghara in Mathura, where Rupa Gosvami sees Gopala; in Vaishakha, return to Govardhana. - 1668: flight from Aurangzeb; Sinhar, the future Nathdvara. - 1801–1807: Ghasiyar, then Nathdvara again.

In Agrahayana 1333 of the Bengali era (December 1926) Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati, having visited Govindaji in Jaipur, travelled via Chittorgarh and Mauli station (Nathdvara Road) to Nathdvara, to see Gopaladeva, the Lord of Madhavendra's heart. In a letter to the journal “Gaudiya” (year 5, nos. 22–23) he related that the master of the temple, Sri Govardhanlal Gosvami, was like a feudal prince with his own guard; that the worship was richer than any in India — some fifteen hundred coins a day for offerings, some fifteen hundred cows, its own market and library; and that the chief manager was still called “Krishnadasji” — the name had become the title of the office. Gosvami Maharaja received the guests, spoke with them about Hari for half an hour, arranged darshana for them at the evening arati, which he performed himself, and sent them maha-prasada. Shrinathji is Madhavendra's Deity, whom Mahaprabhu saw and honoured, and the Gaudiyas come before Him with the deepest reverence.

The Traditions of Vallabha's Followers

Vallabhacharya himself and his son Vitthalanatha always honoured Madhavendra. But later many stories entered the books of their sampradaya which the Gaudiya tradition considers groundless, historically self-contradictory and born of envy: in them both Madhavendra, the first architect of the rasa of loving devotion, and Gaurasundara Himself are belittled.

The “252 Vartas” (varta 251) relate that Madhavendra, a sannyasi of the Madhva sampradaya, lived at Arail, and Vitthalanatha studied with him daily: he would leave his books behind, yet recite his lessons ten times better than his teacher. In a dream Shrinathji revealed to Madhavendra that He had appeared in the form of Vitthalanatha to teach service, and Madhavendra asked the youth for one thing as his teacher's fee — to make him his servant. Vitthala refused — “You are my teacher” — but at the command of Navanitapriya placed him in the service of Shrinathji together with the Bengali servitors. Madhavendra gave away all the gifts to the Bengali brahmanas; Shrinathji told him to bring Malaya sandalwood, and when he had gone south, Krishnadasa Adhikari expelled the Bengalis.

The Gaudiya authors answer this with the words of the Vallabhite books themselves: Vitthala was born in 1437 Shaka, and when the Lord came to Arail he was not yet born or was an infant, while Madhavendra had long since withdrawn. Madhavendra was the guru of the guru of the guru of Vitthala's father; to make him Vitthala's disciple is both a spiritual offence and historical suicide. And by calling Vitthala Purna Purushottama, the Lord Himself, the authors show themselves to be ahamgrahopasakas — those who worship a man as God. Moreover, the “Vallabha-digvijaya” itself calls Madhavendra Vallabha's teacher in the Vaishnava scriptures; hence the story that Vitthala made his father's teacher his

own disciple is false both historically and spiritually: a teacher of knowledge, as the “Bhagavatam” and the “Narada-pancharatra” teach, is to be honoured on a par with Vishnu.

According to the “Nij-varta” (episodes 21–22), immediately after 1576 Vikrama (1441 Shaka) Vallabha — since the kinsmen of the headman Sadu Pande did not know how to serve — called the brahmanas of Sri-kunda, servants of Krishna Chaitanya, and placed Madhavendra Puri at the head of the service: “a Telugu brahmana, an acharya of the Madhva sampradaya, the guru of Krishna Chaitanya, with whom the Acharyaji studied the Vedas in Kashi”; Vitthala was then four years old. Vallabha kept Madhavendra's disciples in the service, made Krishnadasa manager and gave the kirtana to Kumbhandasa. The Bengalis served for fourteen years, and then, at Shrinathji's “command,” Avadhuta Dasa and Krishnadasa expelled them for “theft,” and the service passed to Gujarati brahmanas. According to the “Vallabha-digvijaya,” at the new temple “Madhava with his disciples” was appointed to the service.

The Gaudiya side regards this appointment as pure invention: the testimony of the “Charitamrita” deserves more credence. Vallabha's followers wished to present Gopala as theirs “from the very beginning” and portrayed Vallabha's aged teacher, a detached paramahamsa, as a hired priest. And if the wealthy kshatriya who built the temple was Puranmal, then the Vallabhite dates are wrong; probably the first temple for Madhavendra was built by some other wealthy kshatriya of Mathura, while Puranmal of Ambala, having later become Vallabha's disciple, erected a larger one.

The “Chaurasi Baithak” (baithak 21) moves the place of Gopala's appearance to Bhandiravana and relates that the head of the Madhva seat, Vyasatirtha, told Vallabha there: “Madhavendra Puri is my disciple, and his disciple is Krishna Chaitanya,” and offered him his own seat; but at night Vallabha's servants beat Vyasatirtha, and he became Vallabha's disciple. In other versions — the “Sampradaya-pradipa” of Gadadhara Dasa Dvivedi, the “Vallabha-digvijaya” (2), the “Nij-varta” (4) — this is a debate at Vidyanagara before Krishnadeva Raya: Vyasatirtha wished to give Vallabha sannyasa, but Bilvamangala (or Shrinathji) in a dream told him not to accept the Madhva path; in the “Nij-varta” there is no beating. The Gaudiya authors see in all this a fabrication meant to belittle the teachers of the Brahma-Madhva-Gaudiya sampradaya, and remark with sorrow that it is lamentable to print tales of violence as history: of the fate of those who revile Vaishnavas the “Bhakti-sandarbha” speaks (265, citing the “Skanda Purana”). The tale of the beating, they suggest, arose because the Tattvavadi Vyasatirtha had routed the doctrine of shuddhadvaita.

The “Sampradaya-pradipa” calls Chaitanya “a sub-sampradaya of Vishnusvami”; the Gaudiyas reply that the Lord called an interpretation contrary to Shridhara Svami “the opinion of a harlot,” and Vallabha accepted the correction. The “Chaurasi Baithak” (10) asserts that Chaitanya prostrated Himself before Vallabha at Manasi-Ganga and by his mercy saw her “milky form,” and baithak 4 that Gopala Bhatta, on Chaitanya's advice, received the appearance of Radha-ramana from Vallabha and in his next birth became a Pushtimargi, “Gopala Naga.” But Radha-ramana appeared in 1599 of the Vikrama era (so in the “Sri Radha-ramanera seva-prakata,” a book seen in the possession of Banamali Lal Gosvami Vidyabhushana) — twelve years after Vallabha's departure (1587); and the Lord met Vallabha only at Arail and at Nilachala.

The Gaudiya authors also reject the charge of greed against the Gosvamis: Rupa and Raghunatha gave up ministerial posts, slept under the same tree for one night only and ate dry chickpeas; Rupa in the “Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu” accepted the path of pushti of the early Vallabha; the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” (110) sees in Vallabha Bhatta Shuka, and the Gaudiyas always honoured both Vallabha and Vitthala. The Pushtimarga, for its part, portrays Vitthalanatha as “the guru of his own parama-guru”; according to historians, the cult of enjoyment in it began under Vitthala's fourth son, Gokulanatha (F. S. Growse, “Mathura,” 1880). Because an offence against Madhavendra's feet had been

committed in the Pushtimarga from the time of its forefathers, the Gaudiyas say, the seed of it grew into the worldly sahajiya of householders (cf. CC, Antya 8.97); neither Vallabha nor Vitthala encouraged anything of the kind.

Govardhana Today

The places connected with Madhavendra survive at Govardhana to this day. On 18 October 1932 they were visited by a disciple of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta. Govinda-kunda lies south of Anor (Annakuta-grama) at the foot of Govardhana, and on its southern bank they show the spot where Madhavendra sat. The place where he cleared the thicket and found Gopala also survives; at the entrance is a stone tablet: “Appearance of Sri Nathaji — samvat 1535, Vaishakha, dark fortnight, ekadashi, nakshatra Dhanishtha,” and on the veranda an inscription in Hindi: “Built by order of Purushottamji Maharaja (Vallabha sampradaya) by the Vaishnava Govinda Dasa Garsola, samvat 1721.” An outcrop of Giriraja can be seen there.

From below, pilgrims bow to the ruins of the temple of Gopalaji on Giriraja, associated with Madhavendra. West of Anor, on the other side of Govardhana, lies the village of Gopalapur, where Gopala appeared; here the Vrajavasis, at Krishna's word, worshipped Govardhana, and nearby on the stone of the hill can be seen the marks of a pot of curd and of Krishna's lotus; not far from the place of appearance is Annakuta-sthana. Old Vrajavasis say that Yatipura was formerly called Gopalapur, after Gopala, and was renamed after His devotee — Madhavendra Yati, who sought not a drop of fame, yet whose fame surpassed the name of the Lord Himself. According to another explanation, Vallabhacharya bought land at the foot of Govardhana and built houses there, and the place came to be called Yatipura because Madhavendra, “the best of yatis,” had lived there.

From Giriraja one can see in the distance the ruins of the temple where Madhavendra's two disciples from Gauda served Gopala. Later, at Gopala's command in a dream, the kshatriya merchant Puranmal built a temple beside it — from afar the two look like a pair of shrines, the main one and a chamber for rest. Its spire, it is said, was destroyed by Aurangzeb, and Dvarakesha Maharaja of the Vallabha sampradaya restored it about a hundred years ago.

Around Shrinathji and Govardhana

Over the centuries many traditions grew up around Madhavendra's Gopala, and by no means all of them are friendly to the Gaudiyas. Above they were mentioned briefly; here the most telling of them are gathered — together with what the Gaudiya biographies answer. The Vallabhite works are reported as the books themselves tell them, and the judgements as the biographies of the Gaudiya Vaishnavas give them.[20]

Vallabha, Vyasatirtha and Vishnusvami

Even the meeting at Arail the Vallabhite books tell in their own way. According to the “Nij-varta” and the “Sampradaya-pradipa,” Vallabha, recognising his guest as Krishna Chaitanya and seeing Krishna Himself in His body, told his wife to feed Him rice not offered to the Deity, and to her doubt replied: “Krishna, who dwells in His heart, will surely taste it”; after staying a few days, the Lord went on “to His own place,” Vrindavana. The Gaudiya biographies do not quarrel over details: one way or another, then or later, Vallabha and his sons received the mercy of the Lord and His associates. The trouble lies in the later books of the sampradaya: exalting Vallabha, they spared neither Madhavendra, whom Vallabha and Vitthala always honoured, nor Gaurasundara Himself — and they agree poorly with one another besides.

Nowhere is this plainer than in the stories about Vyasatirtha. According to the “Chaurasi Baithak,” when Vallabha was reading the “Bhagavatam” for seven days at Bhandira-vana, the head of the Madhva

seat came of his own accord to offer him his place, a hundred thousand servants and a lakh of rupees, boasting that Madhavendra was his disciple and Krishna Chaitanya Madhavendra's; Vallabha promised to answer the next day, and at midnight four of his servants with cudgels beat the old man, who in the morning himself asked to become Vallabha's disciple. In the “Sampradaya-pradipa” (it is ascribed to Gadadhara Dasa Dvivedi, “called a disciple of Vitthalanatha”) everything takes place at Vidyanagara: Vallabha defeats a Mayavadi before whom the Tattvavadis could not stand for six days, King Krishnaraya bathes him from a golden vessel (this kanakabhisheka is described in detail in the “Nij-varta” and the Gujarati “Kanakabhisheka ka Itihasa”), and Vyasatirtha wants to give him sannyasa and make him acharya of his sampradaya. But in a dream Bilvamangala appears to Vallabha, the last of seven hundred acharyas of Vishnusvami: for seven hundred years — ever since Rudra, by the Lord's will, descended as Shankaracharya and turned people away from bhakti — he had waited here to pass the teaching on to Vallabha, the incarnation of the fire of the Lord's mouth, who together with his sons was to save lakhs of souls by the path of bhakti. In the “Vallabha-digvijaya” this command is given by Bhagavan Himself; in the “Nij-varta” Vyasatirtha only urges Vallabha at night, there is not a word about any beating, and Bilvamangala brings a letter from Vishnusvami himself, after which Govardhananathji appears: “Never accept the sampradaya of Madhvacharya,” — and Vallabha, with certificates of victory, leaves Vidyanagara for Vraja.

The Gaudiya biographies see in all this an invention born of envy: printing robbers' tales as history, the writers make a venerable acharya the patron of thugs, and the author of the “Nyayamrita,” which like the Sudarshana in Vishnu's hand shattered the arguments of the Mayavadis, their victim. Were these thugs perhaps hired by the Mayavadis? And the books contradict themselves: as a child Vallabha studied the Vedas under Madhavendra, the disciple of Vyasatirtha's disciple, while Vitthala supposedly made his own teacher his disciple — whereas the “Bhagavatam” (11.10.12) likens teacher and disciple to the two pieces of wood between which the fire of knowledge is born, and the “Narada-pancharatra” bids one honour the guru who gives knowledge as Vishnu. Vallabha's meeting with Bilvamangala, who lived centuries before him, the devotees do not dispute: great souls are not bound by time; but making earlier saints the disciples of later ones, or having them “beaten by the hands of robbers” — this those who know the truth cannot accept. Nor does the “Vyasayoga-charitam,” cited by Televala, confirm the story: there Krishnadeva Raya honours Vallabha “under the presidency” of Vyasatirtha, which speaks rather of honour paid to Vyasatirtha himself. Nor does it fit the dispute over the “Nyayamrita”: Madhusudana Sarasvati objected to it in the “Advaita-siddhi,” Ramacharya Tirtha answered him in the “Tarangini,” Brahmananda Giri tried to refute the answer, and Vanamala Mishra demolished him — and yet according to the “Nij-varta” Vallabha at Prayaga listens with pleasure to that very Madhusudana. Could the victor over Vyasatirtha's opponent have delighted in the conclusions of a kevala-advaitin? Hence some say plainly: Vyasatirtha routed Vallabha's shuddhadvaita, and for that the story of his beating was invented.

Hence, too, the dispute about sampradaya. The Vallabhite books regard Vallabha as a late member of the sampradaya of the third of three Vishnusvamis (the first they name Devatanu, the second Rajagopala, the teacher of Bilvamangala's teacher, the third Andhra-Vishnusvami; the teaching of Vishnusvami's “Sarva-sukta” is known outside their books as well — to Sayana-Madhava and to Shridhara Svami), and Chaitanya as a “sub-sampradaya of Vishnusvami,” since He honoured Shridhara Svami as jagad-guru. The Gaudiyas recall what happened at Nilachala: when Vallabha wished to read to the Lord his commentary written against Shridhara Svami, Gaurasundara called an opinion opposed to the Svami “the opinion of a harlot,” and Vallabha, bowing his head, accepted the correction. To derive a “sub-sampradaya” from this is, in the logicians' phrase, an argument with the fault of ativyapti: far too broad.

Other Traditions and the Gaudiya Answer

Of the same kind are the stories of the “Chaurasi Baithak”: how the Lord, who lived six months at Manasi-Ganga under a vow not to speak until He had completed a hundred and twenty-five thousand names in the day, supposedly prostrated Himself before Vallabha and by his mercy, together with the Vaishnavas, saw the milky form of Manasi-Ganga — or how Vallabha manifested Radha-ramana from Gopala Bhatta's shalagrama, yet declined to become his guru: “In another birth you will enter the Pushtimarga,” — and in his next life Gopala Bhatta became “Gopala Naga.” Was it not later storytellers, the biographies ask, who made up these absurdities to amuse women? For Vitthalanatha together with Rupa arranged the honouring of Gopala Bhatta at Mathura, and Vallabha himself drank the water that had washed Mahaprabhu's feet; such would-be disciples only wounded his heart. Nor do these stories stand the test of dates: according to an old book on the service of Radha-ramana, He appeared only after the departure of Vallabha, whose year the Vallabhite books themselves give; and the Lord and Vallabha met, by all the books, only at Arail and at Nilachala — when the Lord was wandering through Vraja, Vallabha was at Charanat, and when He returned from there, at Arail.

To the charges of self-interest that the Pushtimargi lawyer Televala levels at the Gaudiya Gosvamis, the biographies answer with a saying: the lustful man sees the whole world full of objects of lust. Rupa and Raghunatha gave up ministerial posts to live only for Krishna's pleasure; whereas stories contrary to history, logic and plain morality were composed in illicit rivalry with Rupa's followers, to strengthen a householder sampradaya with its tamasic bhakti, proud of wealth and numbers of followers. And if Televala is offended by “the opinion of a harlot,” it is only because such a word troubles one who lacks loyalty to the guru and the succession; Vallabha himself accepted it with bowed head. And Vallabha himself the Gaudiyas always honoured: just as Sarvabhauma, once a teacher of Mayavada, became an associate of Gaura, so Vallabha, who had once displayed a scholar's reasoning, was honoured by Gaura's associates as an acharya, and Kavi Karnapura in the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” (110) called him Shuka, the son of Dvaipayana. To seek no honour for oneself but to honour others is the eternal nature of Chaitanya's followers.

Televala himself, however, admits what Vitthala owed to the Gaudiyas. Living at Puri, Vitthaleshvara came close to Chaitanya's followers, and his stotras to Radha — the “Svamini-ashtaka,” the “Svamini-stotra,” such as Vallabha himself has none of — like his commentary on the “Krishna-premamrita” and the “Shringara-rasa-mandana,” arose perhaps under their influence. He admits also the price of the shrine's passing: when Giridhara moved it to his own house in Mathura (in samvat 1623) and Vitthaleshvara elaborated the service, it became the exclusive possession of the Vallabhites, the Bengali Vaishnavas forgot their early connection with it, and the mass of Vaishnavas lost access to it — though the aim, according to Televala, was only to remove the Bengalis, and hardly did Vitthaleshvara or “Vallabhacharya”[21] wish for such an outcome.

At Govinda-kunda and After

How the Gaudiyas fared at Govardhana later on can be seen from the stories that a disciple of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta heard at Govinda-kunda on 18 October 1932. Manohara Dasa Babaji there called the bhajana of the holy name “bhakti turned outward,” and hearing of the lilas “bhakti turned inward.”[22] His disciple Ananta Dasa related that the Vallabhites, who held sway at the kunda, mocked the Gaudiyas, nicknaming them “an-magi,” until Manohara Dasa began to teach boys grammar and the “Bhagavatam” so that they might live by expounding it — then the gosains yielded the Gaudiyas a little room; and when Ramasvarupa Mishra, priest of the gosain Ranchhorlalji, took initiation from him and the Vallabhites were enraged, Manohara Dasa, so that his disciple should not lose his only livelihood, told him to go on adhering to them. Another babaji, Ramakrishna Dasa, who before an assembly of Vallabhites had called Vallabha a disciple of Gadadhara Pandita, was nearly beaten, and later, after a

festival at his ashrama, night visitors of robber-like appearance, demanding money, beat him until he bled.

What the gosains' customs degenerated into the biographies show in the words of the English historian F. S. Growse (“Mathura,” 1880): the cult of enjoyment in the Pushtimarga began under Gokulanatha, Vitthala's fourth son, kinship with whom is claimed by the chief gosain at Bombay as well. According to Growse, the gosains are family men and worldly, “the Epicureans of the East”; Gokulanatha taught the complete identity of the gosain with the Deity, which is conferred by birth and lost through no vice whatever, and the initiate surrenders to the gosain not only the first fruits of his substance but the virginity of his newly wedded wife; these practices were exposed by a libel case in the Supreme Court of Bombay in 1862, and the glorification of immorality is the whole point of many stories of the “Chaurasi varta.” All this is Growse's own; the biographies quote it without additions.

From here the biographies draw a lesson for the Gaudiyas themselves. In Vallabha's “Sannyasa-lakshana” a sannyasa imbued with bhava is accepted, but his present-day followers live as householders, whereas among Mahaprabhu's devotees renunciation is the chief thing; and those Gaudiyas infected with worldly sahajiya ideas reap the poisonous fruits of the same way of thinking. Mahaprabhu, being a sannyasi, cherished the mood of the gopis who prayed that the Lord might ever appear in the minds of them who live at home (“Bhagavatam,” 10.82.48) — yet the worldly sahajiyas decided that a renunciant's dress is incompatible with the vision of the Lord. The sakhi-bhekis, misunderstanding the words “be firm within, and outwardly behave as people do,” fell away from renunciation and took to acting out humility “lower than the grass”; but imitation without inner service is hypocrisy, not bhajana, and this difference is taught by Raya Ramananda's conversation with Mahaprabhu and Sanatana's questions about sadhana and sadhya. In the same way they distort the instruction of the “Bhakti-rasamrita-sindhu” (1.2.295) on serving both in the form of a sadhaka and in the siddha form, following the residents of Vraja, excusing themselves on the ground that the corrupted society of Gaudiyas thinks so — and this betrays only inexperience in bhajana: remembrance of the eight periods of the day not awakened by kirtana is artificial and is not the path of the Gosvamis.[23]

Significance

Madhavendra Puri opened in the line of Madhva what had not been in it before — love for Krishna in separation; and ever since, wherever such love is found, it is sure to have a connection with him (so, according to the “Charitamrita,” the Sanodiya brahmana understood on seeing the Lord; CC, Madhya 17.172–173). Srila Bhaktisiddhanta teaches that transcendental separation is the one practice that leads the soul to perfection. Worldly longing betrays attachment to matter, whereas longing for Krishna is the best evidence of a desire to please Him. The example of Madhavendra, the root of this movement, is a model for everyone who wishes to serve, and Mahaprabhu and His intimates made it their standard.

1. The line “brahmaṇyaḥ puruṣottamaḥ” is read in different ways: some see here one person — Purushottama, “devoted to brahminical culture,” a disciple of Jayadharma on a par with Vishnu Puri; others two teachers, Purushottama and Brahmanya; according to a third reading, Vyasatirtha was a disciple of Purushottama.

2. In one of the texts of the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” cited by the biographies, the line about the tree with four fruits is absent, and in place of the line about Ranga Puri there is another: Gaura accepted Ishvara Puri as His guru and flooded the worlds with love.

3. The sources date Advaita's initiation differently. According to the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Antya 4.419–440), it took place at their first meeting, when Madhavendra was wandering in grief for the world, before the Lord's appearance. According to the “Charitamrita” (Madhya 4.110–111), Madhavendra initiated Advaita later, on his way from Vraja to fetch sandalwood for Gopala, after two years of serving Him. One of the biographies combines the two accounts: it was at the time when Advaita was teaching the “Gita” and the “Bhagavatam” that Madhavendra dreamt of Gopala's command, and on the way he initiated Advaita.

4. One of the biographies says that Advaita, having received Madhavendra's “invitation,” became from then on an unwavering preacher of devotion, whereas before he had taught the path of knowledge (jnana-vada). This is hard to reconcile with the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Antya 4), according to which Advaita was already expounding the “Gita” and the “Bhagavatam” as devotion before meeting Madhavendra.

5. So in the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Adi 9.154). According to the “Bhakti-ratnakara,” the meeting took place at a holy place on the western coast of India; one of the biographies places it in South India, and another says that Nityananda toured the holy places of both North and South and in these travels met Madhavendra, Ishvara Puri and Brahmananda Puri.

6. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta remarks in the “Gaudiya-bhashya” (on CB, Adi 9.187–188) that the question of godbrotherhood is inseparable from the question of the guru and is in essence the same. An old verse in the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (5) honours Nityananda as “dear to Lakshmipati,” and some hold that it was Lakshmipati Tirtha himself who led Him away from home at the age of twelve.

7. According to one of the biographies, the pujari hid Gopala in a thicket on the very summit of Govardhana; according to the “Charitamrita” and the other accounts, in a thicket below, from where the Deity was later carried up the hill.

8. According to some biographies, the strongest of the villagers carried the Deity up the hill and set Him on a great stone throne — so also in the “Charitamrita” (Madhya 4.53–54); according to another, Shripada himself lifted Him and placed Him on a marble throne.

9. According to one of the biographies, it was wealthy kshatriyas who built the temple and gave the ten thousand cows.

10. Literally Gopinatha says “by My maya.” What is meant is not the illusory energy to which the souls of this world are subject, but yogamaya — the Lord's internal potency, which serves His lilas.

11. According to one of the biographies, in the year 1432 of the Shaka era; elsewhere the same biography places the Lord's sannyasa in 1431.

12. So in one of the biographies and in the Vaishnava calendar of the Sri Chaitanya Saraswat Math, where this day is the Gaura-dvadashi of the month of Govinda. Murari Gupta in his “Kadacha” (4.15.8–9) names as the day of Madhava Puri's remembrance, which Advaita observed, the twelfth lunar day of the bright fortnight not of Phalguna but of Chaitra.

13. One of the biographies says that he departed at Remuna. The Vallabhite author Televala writes that he departed in the south, where he had gone for sandalwood, at the age of about a hundred and thirty; according to the “252 Vartas,” there in the south he anointed a certain Hima-Gopalji with sandal paste and entered the eternal lila.

14. According to one historical report, Vitthalanatha, Vallabhacharya's son, was born thirty-two years after Madhavendra's departure. If Vitthalanatha was born in 1515, the departure would fall around 1483 — before the Lord's appearance, which is hard to reconcile with the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” and the “Charitamrita”: Nityananda meets Madhavendra in the years of His wanderings, which began when He was twelve — that is, after the Lord's appearance.

15. The “Chaitanya-bhagavata” calls this festival “the day of the worship (aradhana) of Madhava Puri”; one of the biographies calls it a festival on the day of the guru's appearance.

16. The sources name the month of Vitthalanatha's birth differently: the horoscope gives Pausha, Televala Margashirsha (the ninth lunar day of the dark fortnight, samvat 1572).

17. According to another report, it was in 1499, on the second lunar day of the bright fortnight of Chaitra, that Vallabhacharya installed Gopala on Giriraja, whereas according to the “Nij-varta” on that night Puranmal merely received in a dream the command to build the temple.

18. According to Televala, the protest against the Bengalis was raised by a certain Anantadasa.

19. The reason for Gopala's move to Mathura is given differently. The “Charitamrita” says that Gopala came to Mathura ostensibly out of fear of the Muslims, and so the aged Rupa, no longer able to walk to Govardhana, saw Madhavendra's Deity. According to Televala, Giridhara moved Him to his own house, probably to assert his authority.

20. The biographies cite these works in the Vallabhites' own editions: “Sri Vallabhacharyaji ki Nij-varta” (the manuscript was obtained from Sarasvati, daughter of Seth Mangal Dasa Giridhar Dasa of Ahmedabad; first printed in 1959 Vikrama from four manuscripts, then in Ahmedabad at the Viravijaya Press — by Manilal Chhaganlal, 1979, and by Lalubhai Chhaganlal Desai, 1990 Vikrama); the “Sampradaya-pradipa,” Sanskrit prose ascribed to Pandita Gadadhara Dasa Dvivedi, a disciple of Vitthalanatha, and composed, it is said, in 1610 Vikrama (1475 Shaka; published by the Vidya-vibhaga at Kankroli, Mewar); the Sanskrit “Sri Vallabha-digvijaya” of Yadunatha, the sixth son of Vitthalanatha (born 1613 Vikrama), written in 1658 Vikrama (the time of Vitthalanatha's appearance is given in the “Purva-yatravachchheda,” the stages of Vallabha's sannyasa in the conclusion); “Sri Vallabhacharyaji ki Chaurasi Baithak ke Charitra” (Ahmedabad, published by Lalubhai Chhaganlal Desai, Viravijaya Press; it also gives the horoscope of Vitthalanatha cast by Govindasvami); the Gujarati “Sri Vallabhakhyana tatha Mula-purusha” (published by Govardhanadasa Lakshmidasa, Mumbai, 1955 Vikrama; it gives the same date of Vitthala's birth); “Sri Gosainji ke 252 Vaishnav ki Varta” (edited by Ramadasaji, Lakshmi Venkateshvara Press, Mumbai, 1988 Vikrama; Madhavendra — varta 251); Vallabha's “Anubhashya” on the “Brahma-sutras” with the introductions of its editor, the Pushtimargi author Mulchandra Tulsidas

Televala, advocate of the High Court at Bombay (Nirnaya Sagar Press, 1984 Vikrama, that is, 1926). Besides these — the “Chaurasi Vaishnavan ki Varta” of Gosvami Gokulanathji (in it Ramadasa, on learning of Krishnadasa's death, utters the words of the “Gita” (14.18) “adho gacchanti tāmasāḥ” — “those in the mode of ignorance go down”), the Gujarati “Kanakabhisheka ka Itihasa,” the “Purva-guru-shamsana-vivarana” of Brajanatha, the “Ghar-varta,” the “Sri Radha-ramanera seva-prakata,” F. S. Growse's “Mathura” (2nd ed., 1880) and the journal “Gaudiya” (year 5, nos. 22–23) with Srila Bhaktisiddhanta's letter on Nathdvara.

21. So in Televala, although Vallabhacharya had departed as early as 1530, long before Gopala was moved to Mathura (1567).

22. These are the babaji's own words. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta teaches otherwise: the kirtana of the holy name is not “outward” bhakti but the foundation of bhajana, and remembrance of the lilas that is not awakened through kirtana is artificial (see below, at the end of the section).

23. The sakhi-bhekis are those who, imitating the sakhis of Vraja, outwardly assume a woman's guise; Srila Bhaktisiddhanta counted them, like the sahajiyas, among the currents that have fallen away from Mahaprabhu's teaching. The inner, siddha form of service is not invented or displayed outwardly: it is revealed by the mercy of the guru and the Vaishnavas in a heart purified by the kirtana of the holy name — which is why remembrance not awakened by kirtana is called artificial.